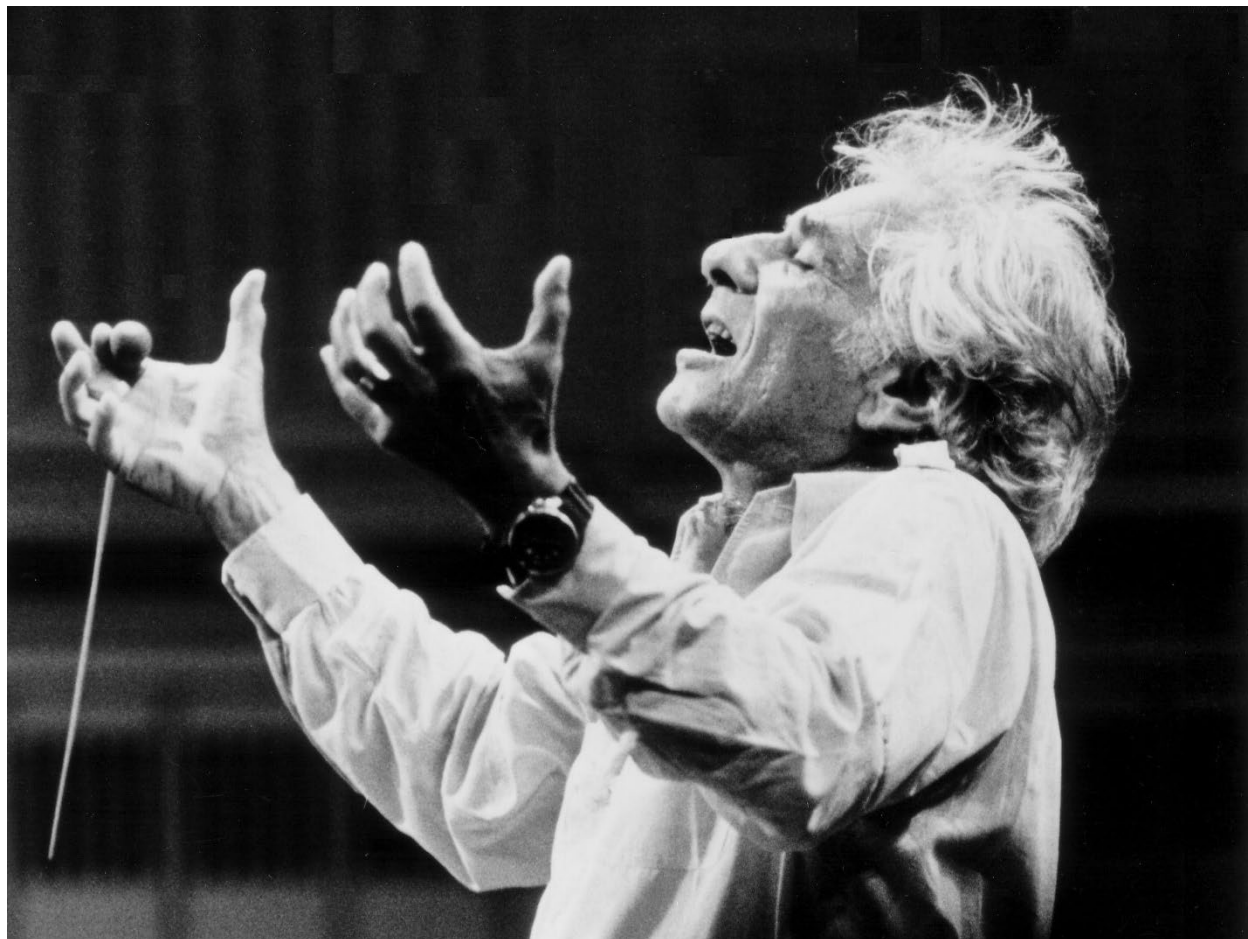


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Conducting America

*How Leonard Bernstein Drove American Idealism
Post World War II*



Paul de Hueck/Courtesy of The Leonard Bernstein Office, Inc.

David Cho

The Infinite Variety of Music

The abstract notion of sounds can encapsulate time. Though only constructed with twelve notes, significantly less than the available number of words in our language, music has infinite possibilities.¹ Music has the ability to describe and evoke what words cannot—it transcends language, presenting meaning understandable to everyone. Though with endless permutations, composers have effectively communicated stories, emotions, and ideas through their compositions. Music presents the opportunity to communicate so clearly with a paradoxically incomprehensible language—music’s ability to touch the souls of individuals is simply magical.² It is these infinite yet controllable possibilities, abstract yet tangible ideas, that make music unlike anything else.

Music is a means to control time—through its tonality, rhythm, and form, music has the ability to bring order. The four musical periods—baroque, classical, romantic, and contemporary—reflected their eras. Art, more broadly, serves as a lens that reveals the social and political trends that define societies. Composers were often aware of the complex developments happening around them. Music provided them with the means to either reflect that change or promote their own change. Understanding the power of music to evoke emotions, some governments employed music as propaganda. Music was and is an integral part of living—it is much more than simply another form of entertainment.³

Thus, an investigation into Leonard Bernstein, one of the defining figures of American music in the second half of the twentieth century, can also provide a perspective into America as a whole. Bernstein dedicated his life, whether through his music or political activities, to establish peace. Through his music, Leonard Bernstein defined America’s change after World War II—he conducted America.

Thesis

Leonard Bernstein was the most prominent artist post-World War II.⁴ From his explosive rise to fame conducting the New York Philharmonic in 1943, Bernstein was an ambassador of American culture—he composed countless American classics and toured the New York Philharmonic around the world, showcasing and demonstrating America’s growing prominence in classical music.⁵ Leonard Bernstein wrote that he felt that he had “lived five lives or so already” towards the end of his career in 1988.⁶ Bernstein was a conductor, composer, pianist, teacher, and activist. Through these “five lives,” he pursued his greater vision for the world: global harmony.⁷

Leonard Bernstein progressed American idealism. An activist calling for equal rights for all citizens, Bernstein composed music to expose America’s discrimination against minorities. *West Side Story*, *1600 Pennsylvania Avenue*, and *Songfest* highlighted America’s suppression of these forgotten individuals. Bernstein extended his fight against prejudice with his role as the conductor of major orchestras. By recruiting and promoting African American and female artists, he challenged their traditional statuses as second-class citizens. Amidst the destruction and turmoil from the Cold war, Bernstein helped people to regain faith with *Mass* and the music he performed in response to violence.⁸ Believing in humanity despite the violence around him, Bernstein placed hope in the next generations. Bernstein understood the political nature of music to act as social commentary. Thus, he democratized music through *Omnibus* and the Young People’s Concerts, making music accessible to millions of viewers worldwide. Nurturing the youth through the transformative power of music, Bernstein inspired the next generations of musicians through *Omnibus* and the Young People’s Concerts. Bernstein helped America move past the Cold war. Using the universal language of music, Bernstein brought the New York

Philharmonic worldwide to promote peace and understanding. Leonard Bernstein drove the American people's vision for peace out of World War II; he dedicated his life to conducting the United States and the world toward unity, harmonizing humanity through music.⁹

Background: A New America

America, and the world, emerged completely changed after World War II. The unprecedented violence and destruction of the war challenged traditional beliefs of faith and science. Disillusioned by the war, many lost faith in humanity.¹⁰ However, in the aftermath of the war, America found new confidence: itself. The United States emerged as the leading nation in the world after WWII.¹¹ The idea of American exceptionalism emboldened the country to be a more active player in international affairs. After WWII, the U.S. sought to shape the world to its ideals, spreading its ideologies and engaging in conflicts to establish those ideas.¹²

The defining development for the remainder of the twentieth century, the Cold War instilled more fear into the already stricken American people. More dread and violence followed WWII as the United States prepared for its ideological war of capitalism versus communism against the Soviet Union. Paranoia embodied by McCarthyism, the witch-trial-like accusations of alleged communists, drove the American government in its campaign against the Soviet Union. National security challenged individual freedoms, and securing "peace" required engaging in conflicts.¹³ Fears of nuclear warfare epitomized by the bombings of Hiroshima and Nagasaki added to the anxiety marked by WWII. Pervasive in all elements of American life, the Cold War tremendously affected American culture.¹⁴

The decades following World War II were times of great changes for the United States. Following the recovery from the Great Depression, the United States witnessed a long economic expansion stimulated by war productions after 1950. In the optimistic climate from the economic growth, the U.S. saw an immense rise in population from a baby boom. The increased birthrate created a youth culture challenging older generations. As this new generation grew in the following decades, they would be one of the main driving forces pushing for change. American demographics and social norms transformed after WWII. New waves of immigration significantly altered the American population. From 1945 to 1960, the non-white population of the United States increased by 41%.¹⁵ Conflicts between races and political turmoil emerged. The voices of American minorities became more heard after World War II. The Civil Rights movement strove for the equality of African Americans, the second wave of feminism challenged women's second-class status, and the gay rights movement sought to end the discrimination against homosexuality.¹⁶

The incredible development of mass entertainment from the introduction of new technologies and the mass production of goods in the United States saw an equally drastic change in American classical music. American classical music lacked a distinct identity—America performed works from different nations rather than composing their own music. European conductors such as Dimitri Mitropoulos and Serge Koussevitzky dominated the great American orchestras. The central sphere of classical music, the concert hall, was limited to the upper class. As Karl Marx argued, classical music was music of the high culture.¹⁷ The era after World War II saw the democratization of music; the emergence of the radio and television gave new outlets for classical music. The introduction of consumer culture and the rise of the middle

class opened the once-exclusive art form to many more ordinary people. Classical music, and music in general, now held the overwhelming power to deliver its messages to the masses.¹⁸

Background: The Rise of Leonard Bernstein

Leonard Bernstein was born in Lawrence, Massachusetts, in 1918 to Jewish immigrants. Leonard Bernstein's religious views were developed during his childhood. Bernstein was very religious from an early age. His father, Samuel Bernstein, was a pious man and his grandfather was a Hasidic rabbi. Samuel read the Talmud, the sacred book of Jewish law, to Bernstein and frequently went to the Temple Mishkan Tefila with him. Bernstein recalled that, at the Jewish Sabbath service, "I used to weep just listening to the choir, cantor, and organ thundering out—it was a big influence on me." Bernstein's childhood instilled faith in him, something he would carry very closely for the rest of his life.¹⁹

The fate of Bernstein's life was set course at the age of ten when his aunt gave him a piano. He recounted: "I remember touching this thing on the day it arrived, just stroking it going mad. I knew, from that moment to this, that music was 'it.' There was no question in my mind that my life was to be about music." Bernstein began taking piano lessons from a neighbor but quickly outgrew her teachings. Three years later, he looked for lessons at the New England Conservatory of Music (NEC), one of the most renowned music schools in the world. Bernstein's father, Samuel Bernstein, opposed his son's musical ambitions. Samuel perceived that musicians garnered little respectability and status and preferred that his son ventured into business instead. Undeterred by his father's opposition, Leonard Bernstein studied at NEC, paying his own tuition with money earned from teaching piano lessons and performing in a jazz

band.²⁰ Under the acclaimed piano teacher Helen Coates, Bernstein continued to progress his talent in playing the piano. He continued to explore music in all forms, listening to the Boston Symphony Orchestra, directing shows with his friends, and performing at his school. Bernstein had decided to dedicate his life to music and wanted to explore everything about it in the next stage of his life—college.²¹

Bernstein graduated from the Boston Latin School in 1935 and subsequently enrolled at Harvard University. Bernstein excelled at Harvard, impressing fellow students and instructors with his gifts in playing the piano and composing music. After graduating from Harvard with honors in music, Bernstein, inspired by Mitropoulos, attended the Curtis School of Music in Philadelphia to study conducting. At the Tanglewood Music Center in the summers during his years at Curtis, Bernstein's conducting was transformed under the mentorship of Koussevitzky, the music director at the Boston Symphony Orchestra.²² Bernstein then moved to New York City in search of opportunities to perform as a conductor. He eventually became the assistant to Artur Rodzinski, the music director of the New York Philharmonic Orchestra.²³

Bernstein's big break came on August 25, 1943, when he was asked to fill in for the sick Bruno Walter, who was to conduct the New York Philharmonic. Despite only having six hours to prepare for the performance, Bernstein brilliantly led the orchestra, garnering wild applause from the audience, national attention, and praise from the media. *The New York Times* wrote about Bernstein's success on its front page, praising his ability to handle the pressure "with no signs of strain or nervousness."²⁴ The performance, which was broadcasted over the radio, immediately thrust Bernstein's career to new heights; it marked the first time a conductor born and trained in the U.S. led a major orchestra. Reporters swarmed to the newly-made star, and orchestras rushed to have the conductor perform with them.²⁵ Bernstein, having developed his conducting and

composing under the best music institutions and mentors, now had the stage to take on the world with his music, one note at a time.

Exposing Evils through Music

Leonard Bernstein brought to light many of the issues America faced domestically surrounding civil rights for racial minorities and women. His *West Side Story*, *1600 Pennsylvania Avenue*, and *Songfest* addressed America's oppression of various minorities. Bernstein was very politically active. An ardent supporter of African Americans, he opened up more musical opportunities for them and actively participated in the Civil Rights movement. In his vision for harmony, Bernstein sought to bring attention to America's flaws to begin amending them.²⁶

West Side Story, a modern adaption of William Shakespeare's *Romeo and Juliet*, examined American flaws that were difficult for many people to confront. In 1947, renowned choreographer Jerome Robbins, a friend of Bernstein, approached him and playwright Arthur Laurents to work on the musical. As the group began on this enormous project, they struggled to find a sponsor; the racial violence that *West Side Story* centered around made the project risky to fund. Bernstein acknowledged that "the idea of ending the first act of a musical with two corpses was considered reprehensible." Stephen Sondheim, the lyricist of the *West Side Story*, had to call his friend Hal Prince to fund the project.²⁷

West Side Story raises awareness of the struggle of immigrants settling in the United States. Though now iconic for its star-crossed lovers of Tony and Maria, *West Side Story* was originally planned as *East Side Story*. Rather than Americans and Puerto Ricans, the two gangs

were at first meant to be Jewish and Catholic. Robbins envisioned the musical to be named after the Lower East Side of Manhattan; these two groups of immigrants battled to control the New York neighborhoods in the early 1900s.²⁸ However, the focus of the musical changed to Puerto Ricans as gang warfare in the Lower East Side faded away towards the 1950s—the social mobility of New York Jews after World War II conflicted with their story and the gang violence in New York shifted to Manhattan’s Upper West Side Story, the home of 600,000 Puerto Rican immigrants. Many Puerto Ricans entered New York City in the 1950s. The influx of Puerto Ricans, and other minorities, prompted many conflicts between them and the residents. Reports of gang warfare among Chicano Americans in Los Angeles arose, prompting the collaborators to consider changing their cast. Bernstein wrote, “we have abandoned the whole Jewish-Catholic premise as not very fresh.”²⁹ *West Side Story* depicts the “harsh life, ethnic hatreds, and gang violence battering the nation’s urban poor.” Leonard Bernstein remarked that “*West Side Story* is one long protest against racial discrimination... That is why we wrote.” In his annotated copy of *Romeo and Juliet*, he wrote, “An out and out plea for racial tolerance.”³⁰ Bernstein and Laurents convinced Robbins that the musical had to reflect the present; thus, the classic *West Side Story* was born.³¹

The music, lyrics, and plot of *West Side Story* portray these conflicts and injustices. Leonard Bernstein, the composer of the music in *West Side Story*, brilliantly infused Latin American music into the score to illustrate the conflict between the racial groups in America. Throughout the musical, Bernstein intensely layered the rhythm to underscore the violence in the musical and the clashing cultures of the Americans and the Puerto Ricans. Bernstein implemented many cross-rhythms, using more than 30 percussion instruments to define each effect clearly. The opening of “America” begins with a 3-2 son clave, a distinctly Latin

American rhythm. A few measures later, quarter triplets begin. Through passages like “America,” Bernstein used contrasting rhythms to highlight the underlying conflict between racial groups.³²

In addition to conflicting rhythms, Bernstein used the tritone to depict the despair in *West Side Story*. The tritone—known as *Diabolus in musica*, “the devil in music,” by musical theorists—was central to the musical’s score. Bernstein utilized this device, which was regarded as the most “dangerous” interval because of its unstable quality, to portray the conflict between the Jets and the Sharks. Marin Alsop, an American conductor Bernstein inspired, described the tritone as “An interval that requires a resolution. And without resolution it just hangs there and makes you uncomfortable.”³³ With his music in *West Side Story*, Bernstein made his audience uncomfortable with the lack of resolution between racial conflicts in the show.

Though *West Side Story* was an immense success, with its film adaptation winning ten Academy Awards, it was criticized for its rather grim message.³⁴ The ending of *West Side Story* with Tony’s cruel death shocked audiences. Instead of ending a cliché living happily ever after, the musical ended with an inescapable hateful reality—it conflicted with America’s self-image as a great nation. The goal of the musical was to bring the reality of “inner city prejudice, bigotry, and racism” to America. Carol Lawrence, the female lead in the opening show, remarked, “It...touched a nerve in the American public—the headlines were screaming [about gang warfare].” Critic Brooks Atkinson stated, “Instead of glamour, [*West Side Story*] offered the poverty-stricken life of Puerto Rican street gangs...It concluded with the violent death of the chief male character.”³⁵

Accordingly, both large institutions and ordinary people resisted *West Side Story*. Columbia Records initially denied issuing a record, and the U.S. State Department refused to

include *West Side Story* in the U.S.-Soviet cultural exchange program. Sellouts were rare in the show's initial run, with hundreds of patrons walking out because of the racial strife the musical addressed.³⁶ Though the show was brilliant, critics were hesitant to praise such a work filled with so much violence. *The New York Times* article wrote, "Although the material is horrifying, the workmanship is admirable."³⁷ Bernstein aimed to address racial strife and raise awareness about it through music, but many institutions and individuals opposed it.

Bernstein's commentary on America's struggle to integrate minorities extended through other works that challenged the power dynamics in the twentieth century. In 1976, Leonard Bernstein and lyricist Alan Jay Lerner introduced *1600 Pennsylvania Avenue* to celebrate the United States Bicentennial. Their Broadway collaboration retold the history of the first hundred years of the American presidency. Bernstein, a firm believer in the Constitution and American justice, sought to create *1600 Pennsylvania Avenue* as a critical examination of U.S. history. Written in the wake of President Nixon's impeachment, the show aimed to confront the residency at the White House—the ruling class was white, and the servants were black. The musical was a series of episodes of presidents and their wives (played by a pair of white actors) with servants (played by a pair of black actors) at the White House.³⁸

1600 Pennsylvania Avenue was an enormous failure because of its uncomfortable message. Critically received, the show closed after seven performances—it was Bernstein's greatest artistic disaster. *The New York Times* commented on the show, saying, "It works most terribly." It was regarded as "simplistic," "sophomoric," and "Bicentennial bore."³⁹ However, recent examinations of the work, such as that by classical music critic Mark Swed attribute the show's failure to its subject matter.⁴⁰ Swed argues that *1600 Pennsylvania Avenue* failed because it "*dared* to tell a story onstage that spans generations that a lot of people didn't want to hear."

Similarly, Jamie Bernstein, the daughter of Leonard Bernstein, also noted that “nobody liked being told painful stories.”⁴¹ *Variety* criticized the work as it “relentlessly chastises the whites in the house for their forbears’ inarguable mistreatment of blacks.”⁴² Bernstein, when discussing the show’s scenes, said, “We are trying to tell the story of the little white lie, by which I mean the big Black lie.” *1600 Pennsylvania Avenue* confronted America’s racial struggles, but the nation was not ready to grasp them.⁴³

Bernstein worked on another composition, *Songfest*, to critically examine the nation’s history ahead of its Bicentennial. The composition is an anthology of musical compositions set to thirteen poems by Americans from the country’s three-hundred-year history—Conrad Aiken, Anne Bradstreet, Julia de Burgos, e.e. cummings, Gregory Corso, Lawrence Ferlinghetti, Langston Hughes, Edgar Allan Poe, Frank O’Hara, Gertrude Stein, Edna St. Vincent Millay, and Walt Whitman. The poetry that Bernstein selected narrates the experiences of American minorities, those forgotten and marginalized by the country. Bernstein expressed his ambivalence towards American history and exceptionalism by introducing the piece with a discordant and unpleasing horn and snare-drum fanfare, a mockery of military triumphalism that symbolized American patriotism. Poems in *Songfest* like “I, Too, Sing America” and “Okay Negroes” explored the history of racism in America. “If You Can’t Eat You Got To” narrated the struggles of living in poverty. “To What You Said” portrayed the discrimination against gay men. Through *Songfest*, Bernstein told the history of America from the perspective of those oppressed.⁴⁴ By highlighting their voices, Bernstein raised awareness of these groups of people.

Leonard Bernstein extended his support to marginalized populations by providing them opportunities in his orchestras. Bernstein was a champion of African Americans and women, both in and beyond the realm of classical music. In 1947, there were no African American

musicians in a major U.S. orchestra—white males dominated the field. Out of the four hundred musicians that auditioned for his New York City Symphony, only three were black, all of whom were not qualified. Bernstein, seeing a structural deficiency of Black education in music, advocated for improvements in music schools and scholarships for black musicians.⁴⁵

Bernstein recruited black musicians and promoted their careers. In 1959, Bernstein hired violinist Sanford Allen, New York Philharmonic's first full-time African American musician. In 1963, he introduced African American pianist Andrew Watts in a Young People's Concert, and later in that same year, he placed the sixteen-year-old in for the ill pianist Glen Gould with the New York Philharmonic. Bernstein's help sparked Watts' incredible career. In 1965, Leonard Bernstein placed James DePreist, a black conductor, as the assistant conductor of the New York Philharmonic. Bernstein used his orchestra as a platform for progressing African Americans' rights.⁴⁶

Believing that "Anything we can do to fight discrimination—in any form or field—will ultimately work toward ameliorating the musical situation," Leonard Bernstein extended his fight for equality outside the concert hall. Bernstein was a passionate supporter of the civil rights movement. He was on the National Committee against Discrimination in Housing and participated in a campaign that advised artists to boycott segregated venues.⁴⁷ When singer Harry Belafonte, who was leading the efforts for a "Stars of Freedom Rally," asked Bernstein to participate in a march for equal voting rights in 1965, he eagerly accepted the invitation and demonstrated his support.⁴⁸

Leonard Bernstein responded to the gender inequalities highlighted by the second wave of feminism. Bernstein aimed to increase women's involvement in classical music. In 1961, Bernstein invited Nadia Boulanger, a famed French music teacher, to conduct a full program at

the Philharmonic. In 1966, Bernstein selected Orin O'Brien, a double bassist, into the New York Philharmonic; O'Brien was the first woman member, besides harpists, in the organization's entire history. A year later, Bernstein chose cellist Evangeline Benedetti as the second woman member.⁴⁹

Bernstein's inclusion of women in the historically male-dominated industry was criticized by many. Zubin Mehta, a conductor, protested against the growing participation of women in classical music: "I just don't think women should be in an orchestra. They become men. Men treat them as equals."⁵⁰ An article from *Time* magazine in 1966 remarked that Orin O'Brien "is as curvy as the double bass she plays."⁵¹ *The New York Times* described her "as comely a colleen as any orchestra could wish to have."⁵² Such was the climate towards women's increasing participation in classical orchestras. Bernstein challenged the traditional composition of the orchestra, prompting many to criticize him.

Leonard Bernstein put his civil rights mission ahead of artistic glory; despite being famed for his accomplishments as an artist, Bernstein was an idealist who used music to progress his progressivism. Bernstein helped people with acquired immune deficiency syndrome (AIDS) in the 1980s. He performed concerts to raise money for AIDS research and patient care. On November 16, 1989, Bernstein declined the National Medal of Arts, the highest honor for artistic achievement in the United States. He refused the medal because the government agency awarding the medal had revoked a fund for Artists Space, a New York City art show on the suffering from AIDS.⁵³

Leonard Bernstein's mission in fighting for the oppressed and the forgotten was unrivaled by any other musician. Bernstein believed that "even the most dedicated artist was also a citizen,

implicated in the well-being of the larger society.” Throughout his life, Bernstein fulfilled that call to service with his music.⁵⁴

Rediscovering Faith

Leonard Bernstein lived through a time of great violence and turmoil. Bernstein witnessed the struggles of the Great Depression, the horrors of World War II, and the tensions in the Cold War. Moving past these political strifes, he found hope in one man to lead the United States: John F. Kennedy. Bernstein admired Kennedy’s “New Frontier” and the president’s call for all Americans to challenge themselves. Kennedy’s idealism and empowerment of the youth resonated with Bernstein; he regarded Kennedy as the “most moving and compassionate and lovable” of political men.⁵⁵ Kennedy was a patron of the arts; he shared the same passion Bernstein had for promoting the arts. Kennedy and his wife, Jacqueline, invited Bernstein to perform in a concert and compose a fanfare before his inauguration. Bernstein quickly became great friends with the Kennedys, seeing the president as the embodiment of American progressivism.⁵⁶

The news of Kennedy’s assassination in Dallas on November 22, 1963, shocked Bernstein; he recalled, “The murder in Dallas, for me, was the worst experience of my life.” In response to Kennedy’s assassination, Bernstein said, “This will be our reply to violence: to make music more intensely, more beautifully, more devotedly than ever before.” Bernstein led the New York Philharmonic in a televised memorial concert for Kennedy, performing Gustav Mahler’s *Resurrection* Symphony. He remarked that,

We played the Mahler symphony not only in terms of resurrection for the soul of one we love, but also for the resurrection of hope in all of us who mourn him. In spite of our shock, our shame, and

our despair, we must somehow gather strength for the increase of man, strength to go on striving for those goals he cherished. In mourning him, we must be worthy of him.

Bernstein dedicated *Kaddish*, another work on religion, to John F. Kennedy before its premiere in Tel Aviv. Through all the violence he experienced, Bernstein held onto his belief that the beauty of art could lead humanity out of despair, reasoning that “if humans could create and appreciate musical harmony, then surely they were capable of replicating that very same harmony in the world they lived in.”⁵⁷

After John F. Kennedy’s death, Bernstein sought to “make music more intensely, more beautifully, more devotedly than even before.”⁵⁸ Jacqueline Kennedy, still a great friend of Bernstein, requested him to compose a piece for the opening of the John F. Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts in 1971.⁵⁹ *Mass*, the work Bernstein composed for the center, was an attempt “to communicate as directly and universally as I can a reaffirmation of faith.” The United States was torn apart by its engagement in Vietnam War during the late 1960s. Resentment toward the draft, reports of the horrors such as the My Lai Massacre, and the suppression of protestors drove a sweeping anti-war movement across the nation. Embodied by the Kent State massacre, a troubled youth culture emerged, losing faith in the government and humanity.⁶⁰

Mass responds to the young Americans losing faith—it gave them a voice.⁶¹ Bernstein composed the work inspired by the Tridentine Mass of Kennedy’s Roman Catholic Church, which was the core ritual for Catholics; the prayers sung in the mass served as petitions, praises, and affirmations of faith. By infusing the piece with sacred and secular texts—using liturgical passages in Latin and Hebrew, and contemporary texts in English—Bernstein challenged the original meaning of the prayers. The commentaries Bernstein added throughout the work created tension, challenging authority and contemporary issues, particularly the Vietnam War. A

Celebrant leads a congregation in the two-hour work composed for two hundred performers. He confronts his belief, challenging them with difficult questions: “Would a loving God allow wars? Would He let people die in accidents?” At the climax, the Celebrant, defeated by the disillusionment of the violence around, throws the sacraments onto the floor and rejects faith. However, at the end of *Mass*, the Celebrant rediscovers his faith, saying, “The Mass is ended; go in peace.” *Mass* served as a reaffirmation of faith. Bernstein remarked that in the piece, “You go through an enormous amount of despair, protest, and agony, and you come out believing that tomorrow will come, and you have recovered faith somehow.” The tension Bernstein created in *Mass* reflected the turmoil the U.S. faced in the 1960s. However, like the ending of *Mass*, faith in God and humanity were restored. As Bernstein described it, *Mass* served as a “reaffirmation of faith and hope for universal peace.”⁶² Through it, Bernstein recaptured some of the faith in humanity embodied by Kennedy that was lost.

Leading the Next Generation

A firm believer in youth, Leonard Bernstein “was proudest of his own achievements as a teacher.” Bernstein spent his whole life teaching. His revolutionary show *Omnibus* and his televised performances from Young People’s Concerts inspired the next generation of classical musicians. Bernstein helped launch many careers by giving young artists many opportunities through his projects, orchestras, and programs. A teacher for his whole life, Bernstein taught at many institutions, giving lectures at Harvard University and teaching at Brandeis and Tanglewood.⁶³

Bernstein began his television career with *Omnibus* in 1954. An hour-long program on Sundays, the *Omnibus*, meaning “for all” in Latin, ran from 1952 to 1961 on CBS, ABC, and NBC. Exploring classical music in all forms, Bernstein made great use of the new technologies in the twentieth century, such as the television, to broaden the accessibility of music. Many critics raved about Bernstein’s show—it was the standard of educational television programming.⁶⁴ *The New York Times* praised Bernstein’s teaching, remarking that “Mr. Bernstein spoke simply, cogently and without condescension or artiness as he made his points.”⁶⁵ *Omnibus* reached people of diverse backgrounds and musical levels.⁶⁶ Through television and mass media, Bernstein allowed people to experience the joys of music.

Bernstein’s Young People’s Concerts inspired the next generation of musicians. The Young People’s Concerts, initiated by Ernest Schelling in 1924, was a nationally televised series of concerts by the New York Philharmonic. From 1958 to 1972, Bernstein directed the concerts, helping them garner unprecedented recognition. Interested in reaching the widest audience possible, Bernstein used the concerts to introduce music to boys and girls of all backgrounds. During the concerts, Bernstein explored a diverse range of topics, from “What does music mean?” to “Humor in Music.” Bernstein believed that music was for everyone. Through the fifty-three Young People’s Concerts he led, Bernstein gave the gift of music to his audience. Bernstein shared his passion for classical music in the concerts; his excitement was contagious.⁶⁷

Bernstein democratized and expanded beyond classical music through the Young People’s Concerts. The broadcasts from the show broke down the elitist image of the concert hall. Children across the nation learned about the power of classical music from their television sets at home. Bernstein explored the works of all types of music, from Mozart to Elvis, saying that “music just is [music].” Through his gift of being able to share his passion for music,

Bernstein introduced children to the joys of music, a transformative language for self-expression, communication, and creativity.

Critics praised Bernstein's ability to communicate with children so effectively. *Variety* commented on his gift for teaching:

The Philharmonic's conductor has the knack of a teacher and the feel of a poet. The marvel of Bernstein is that, like the writer of television melodrama, he knows how to grab attention and how to carry it along, measuring just the right amount of new information to precede every climax.

Bernstein's teaching did not simply inform the youth about music—it empowered them with music. A skillful communicator of music, he inspired the children of the baby boom to embrace classical music.

The Young People's Concerts were incredibly successful, reaching an extraordinary number of viewers. The concerts, like *Omnibus*, set the standard for television. The series became so successful that CBS broadcasted it at 7:30, the prime time for viewing. Bernstein's teachings reached the entire world, with the programs being translated into twelve other languages and syndicated to forty countries. In the first ten years of the show under Bernstein, the Young People's Concerts won nine Emmy Awards and three Thomas Alva Edison awards as the Best Children's Television Program of the Year.⁶⁸

Leonard Bernstein empowered the youth by providing them with many opportunities. Bernstein used the Young People's Concerts as a platform to introduce rising musicians. After 1960, Bernstein dedicated an episode called "Young Performers" every year to expose exciting talents to the musical world. It was in these episodes that musicians Andre Watts, Horacio Gutierrez, Sergiu Luca, Elmar Oliveria, Young Uck Kim, Stephen Kates, Lynn Harrell, Gary Karr, Heidi Lehwald, and Paula Robison, and conductors Seiji Ozawa, Claudio Abbado, James DePreist, Sylvia Caduff, and Helen Quach were first introduced at a larger stage—a diverse

group, all of whom would go on to have immensely successful careers after. Bernstein's Young People's Concerts served as a springboard for many aspiring musicians.⁶⁹

On November 29, 1962, Leonard Bernstein introduced the world to one of the greatest cellists of all time: Yo-Yo Ma. Bernstein presented a seven-year-old Yo-Yo Ma and his eleven-year-old sister Yeou-Cheng Ma to Presidents John F. Kennedy and Dwight D. Eisenhower at "An American Pageant of the Arts." Before the duo performed the first movement of the Concertino No. 3 in A Major by Jean-Baptiste Breval, Bernstein made a few remarks about Yo-Yo Ma's journey to the United States:

An aspect of that double stream of art I mentioned earlier flowing into and out of America, has long been the attraction of our country to foreign artists, and scientists and thinkers, who have come not only to visit us, but often to join us as Americans, to become citizens of what to some has historically been the land of opportunity and to others the land of freedom... A 7-year-old Chinese cellist, playing old French music, for his new American compatriots. Welcome Yo-Yo Ma and Yeou-Cheng Ma.⁷⁰

Bernstein believed that America was a land of opportunity for everyone. He envisioned the nation as promoting the flourishing of all arts and science. Through Bernstein's advocacy of the arts, he gave young musicians like Yo-Yo Ma a chance to shine.

The Cold War

Leonard Bernstein helped ease the tensions in the Cold War by serving as a cultural ambassador and spreading American values. Bernstein performed in Latin America, the USSR, and Berlin during the Cold War; he used music to connect people around the world.

Music is a language that bridges cultural and ideological differences. Leonard Bernstein understood the common understanding of music and utilized it in connecting the world.⁷¹ Challenging the Cold War climate of hostility, Bernstein called for international cooperation.

Acting as a cultural ambassador of the United States, he used this universal language to promote understanding between the combatting nations in the Cold War.⁷² Attempting to use music to achieve the peace he envisioned, Bernstein conducted the New York Philharmonic on ten overseas tours from 1958 to 1976, playing in over two hundred fifty concerts outside North America.⁷³

In line with Bernstein's belief in the political potential of art, the U.S. government adopted art as a means to create friendly relations and assert American influence. Thus, it sent orchestras outside the nation to display the flourishing culture of democracy to the world. Throughout the 1950s, Leonard Bernstein was one of the most prominent artists whom the U.S. utilized in its cultural mission.⁷⁴

In 1958, the President's Special Projects Program commissioned a tour for Leonard Bernstein as part of the U.S.'s cultural offensive.⁷⁵ *The New York Times* praised the selection of Bernstein and the New York Philharmonic as the artists for the tour: "It would be hard to make a more intelligent choice of a cultural ambassador than this orchestra." The article further supported the tour, stating that "the Philharmonic is the ideal spokesman" because "the message it brings transcends geography or the tongues of men." Through music, a language "mankind is fortunate in possessing," the orchestra would be able to speak for the U.S. in Latin America.⁷⁶

Bernstein took the New York Philharmonic on tour to twelve countries in Latin America. The tour was very successful despite the political hostilities between the U.S. and Latin America from the Cold War and U.S. imperialism. Bernstein and the Philharmonic were welcomed with great affection from the public. They received "delirious" and "frenetic" ovations from their audiences, and local news praised them. One Chilean paper described Bernstein as a "rare and precious present" from the United States. A Peruvian critic praised the tour for it "affords us the

opportunity of witnessing the heights of perfection which may be reached as a result of constant effort and practice.”⁷⁷

The image of Bernstein’s warm reception from fans was greatly contrasted by the rocks thrown at Vice President Richard Nixon’s limousine. As Bernstein was touring in 1958, Nixon visited the continent for diplomatic relations. While Bernstein’s tour of Latin America was an enormous success, Nixon’s visit was defined by hatred. Crowds enraged by the U.S.’s support of right-wing dictators in Latin America swarmed Nixon’s motorcade, forcing him to hide under armed guards.⁷⁸ A little later after the incident, Nixon met with Bernstein to discuss politics and music at a diplomatic dinner. While Bernstein reported to Nixon “tumultuous receptions; record crowds; cheering, stamping audiences; kisses; roses; embraces,” the vice president reported the harsh reception he received.⁷⁹ Upon evaluating why the two men had such contrasting experiences, Bernstein remarked that he had “music on his side.”⁸⁰ Bernstein and his orchestra touched Latin America with music. Bernstein believed that “We can never overestimate the good that comes from artistic communication. When we touch one another through music, we are touching the heart, the mind, and the spirit all at once.”⁸¹

Bernstein was “very happy over the results of the tour.”⁸² The tour’s success and mission were not ignored by the U.S. government. President Eisenhower wrote a letter to the New York Philharmonic, praising them for their “excellent accomplishment” overseas. He wrote that through the orchestra’s tour in Latin America, the U.S. had “drawn closer to the ideal of mutual understanding and friendship which is our goal.” Vice President Nixon saw the effectiveness of Bernstein’s mission and hoped to continue similar programs in the future that would help “reach even deeper into the hearts and minds of our friends around the world.”⁸³

A year later, Bernstein and the New York Philharmonic went on tour again into even more hostile territory. Arranged by President Eisenhower's Special International Program for Cultural presentations, the tour ventured into the Iron Curtain.⁸⁴ Bernstein led fifty concerts in seventeen countries in the ten-week tour through Eastern Europe and the Soviet Union. The American government hoped that the tour, funded by the American National Theater and Academy (ANTA), would promote the reputation of the United States through the virtuosity of Leonard Bernstein.⁸⁵

The tour marked the first time the New York Philharmonic had performed in communist countries. In the three months they spent in the Soviet Union, Bernstein and Philharmonic received excellent reviews, with *The New York Times* calling the tour a "Philharmonic Triumph." *The New York Times* further attributed "Mr. Bernstein's showmanship" that "apparently broke down all barriers." The orchestra's farewell program in Moscow was described as "one of the greatest receptions any body of musicians has had in Russia since Rasputin was a pup [1900]" by *The New York Times*.⁸⁶ Despite some resistance to Bernstein's performances, notably reviewer Aleksandr Medvedev's criticism of "immodest" and "conceited" Bernstein, the audiences admired his efforts to promote friendship, peace, and understanding.⁸⁷

Bernstein sought to unite the Soviets and Americans through music. Before the performance at the farewell concert in Tchaikovsky Hall, Leonard Bernstein gave a thirty-minute lecture about the similarities between Russian and American music. Using the Philharmonic to demonstrate the excerpts of music he explored, Bernstein proclaimed that Russians and Americans were rather similar, despite their tensions in the Cold War. The message preceding the performance was broadcasted to the United States as well. Bernstein expressed that the two

nations had “come a long way toward being closed together.” He embodied the hope people had in ending the strife between the U.S. and the Soviet Union.⁸⁸

Bernstein visited both East and West Germany three times during the Cold War. Bernstein first visited Germany in 1948. Upon arriving, Bernstein saw the utter destruction of war—the country was in ruins as starving people struggled through the rubbles of cities. Though Bernstein was a Jew and understood that Nazi sentiment still existed in the country, he sought to overcome these challenges through music. Bernstein, the first American conductor to perform in Germany since World War II, strove to use the tour as a way to confront hatred and promote understanding.⁸⁹

Bernstein’s next visit to Germany came in 1961 when he toured West Berlin, the embodiment of Cold War tensions. In a discussion of music and politics, Bernstein argued that the age of nationalism in music was passed. Trying to break apart the animosity between opposing nations, Bernstein said the “heyday of narrow nationalism is, or should be, over.” Performing Beethoven with the New York Philharmonic in front of Germans, Bernstein explained the reason for his visit: “We have come to take one more step through this kind of cultural exchange along the paths of international understanding that lead to peace.”⁹⁰ Like in Moscow, Bernstein was warmly welcomed by the native audiences. East and West German critics praised the orchestra’s performances and admired Bernstein’s virtuosity. Through music, Bernstein eased tensions between opposing nations in the Cold War, connecting humanity with the universal language of music.⁹¹

Bernstein came to Berlin one last time in 1989 on December 23 to celebrate the freedoms he had advocated for his entire life. The Berlin Wall had fallen on November 9, 1989, presaging the imminent collapse of the Iron Curtain. Bernstein conducted Beethoven’s Ninth Symphony in

East and West Berlin to celebrate the dismantling of the Berlin Wall. Leading an orchestra composed of musicians from Germany and the four nations that had defeated Germany in WWII, Bernstein reunited old belligerents as allies. With one hundred million people watching the broadcasted concerts, the performances of Beethoven's "Ode to Joy" as "Ode to Freedom" symbolized the world moving past the tensions in the Cold War.⁹²

Conclusion

Leonard Bernstein did much more than progress American idealism; he embodied America's story. America lacked a musical identity in the classical world before World War II—the major orchestras in the nation were led by Europeans, and they performed works from other nations. Bernstein, the first American conductor to lead a major orchestra, helped America assert itself as a leading figure in composing. Just as the United States became a world leader in world politics after World War II, Bernstein helped the nation find its voice in the classical music world.⁹³

Bernstein's legacy is remembered through the countless numbers of works he composed and the many lives he touched with his music. Throughout his career, Bernstein earned twenty-one Grammy Awards. His television career with *Omnibus* and the Young People's Concerts was equally as impressive, earning an incredible number of awards.⁹⁴ Though he received intense criticism and was heavily investigated by the FBI, Bernstein never gave up his mission to make the world a better place, using music as a platform to help marginalized populations and challenge unjust institutions and practices.⁹⁵ Bernstein's teachings persist today; the educational institutions that he helped grow continue to nurture the next generations of musicians.

Recordings of his performances, lectures, and concerts eternalize his life. Bernstein's music and teaching left an enduring legacy.

For Bernstein, music was the language that had no limitations. It could connect people, drive social change, and make the world a better place. Humphrey Burton, the former head of music and arts of the BBC, eloquently paid tribute to Leonard Bernstein: "The man who gave us excitement in the concert hall and sent us out happy. You leave most of his pieces with a glimmer of hope."⁹⁶

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